

Understanding **BPD**

When Your Parent Has BPD

What is happening at home, why you didn't cause it, and what you can do starting this week.



Questions you've probably asked

Why is my parent fine one minute and furious the next?

Did I do something to cause this?

Is it always going to be like this?

Honestly, these are the questions I wish someone had answered for me a lot sooner. They sound simple, but most kids carry them around for years without ever saying them out loud.

If one of your parents, another family member, or someone you love has BPD, or you think they might, I wrote this for you. Most of what's out there about BPD is written for the person who has it, or for their partner. Very little is written for the kid down the hall, even though somewhere between 17 and 25 percent of kids worldwide live with at least one parent who has a mental illness (Van Schoors and colleagues, 2023). You are definitely not the only one. Everything in here comes from research I spent the summer digging through, plus what I learned by living it.

If someone is in danger right now

Call or text 988, any hour of the day. If someone could die, call 911. More numbers are near the end of this guide.

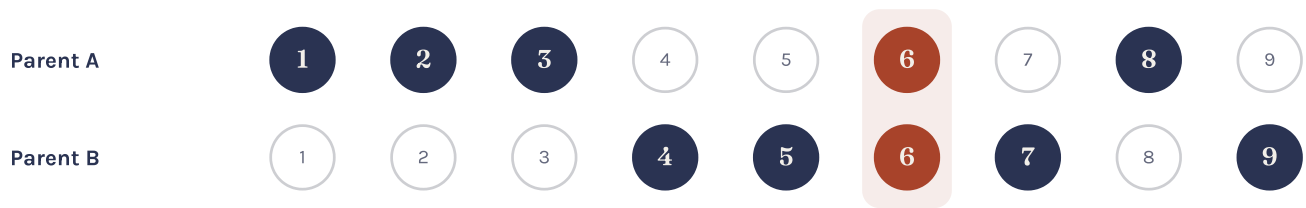
What is BPD, in plain words?

Borderline personality disorder is a mental illness that affects how a person handles their emotions. Feelings hit faster and harder, and they take longer to fade than they do for most people. Relationships feel really high-stakes, because the person is often terrified of being left.

Doctors diagnose it from a list of nine traits, and a person needs five or more. I think it helps to see the actual list, because most people only know BPD from TV or TikTok, and the real thing looks a lot different.

- 1 Working hard to avoid being left, even when nobody is leaving.
- 2 Relationships that swing between adoring someone and resenting them.
- 3 A shaky sense of who they are.
- 4 Impulsive choices that can hurt them, like overspending or reckless driving.
- 5 Self-harm, or threats or attempts of suicide.
- 6 Moods that change fast, often within hours.
- 7 A long-lasting feeling of emptiness.
- 8 Intense anger that's hard to control.
- 9 Under heavy stress, feeling paranoid or unreal.

Same diagnosis, one trait in common



Each circle is one trait from the list above. Both parents qualify for the diagnosis, and the only trait they share is number six. Five or more out of nine can be met in 256 different ways.

So your parent has their own version of BPD. The way to understand it is to learn their patterns: what sets them off, how long it lasts, and what helps them calm back down.

Why does my parent seem like two different people?

One day your parent is the most fun person you know. The next day you're walking on eggshells. The day after that, they act like nothing happened. If you've ever wondered which one is the real them, you're not alone.

Researchers who study parents with BPD describe the same pattern. A parent can swing between two modes (Stepp and colleagues, 2012). In one, they're controlling and harsh: criticizing you, checking up on you, angry about small things. In the other, they pull away and become distant and hard to reach.

A lot of kids decide one of these is the real parent and the other is an act. Honestly, both are real. Both come from the same illness, and neither one is a verdict on you.

BPD also makes people see others in all-or-nothing terms. On Monday you're the only one who understands them. On Tuesday you're selfish and ungrateful. You stayed the same person between Monday and Tuesday. Their view of you swung, and it will probably swing back.

Did I cause this?

No. There's a saying from Al-Anon, a support group for families, that fits here too: you didn't cause it, you can't control it, and you can't cure it.

BPD grows out of a mix of genes and life experience, usually long before a person has kids. Nothing you said at dinner caused it, and no amount of perfect behavior will fix it.

How understanding the illness helps you

Of course, understanding an illness won't make it go away, and it won't make every hard day easier. Still, I really believe it's the most useful thing in this guide, and the research agrees. A review of 37

studies found that kids whose parent has a mental illness do better when someone explains the illness in words they can follow (Van Schoors and colleagues, 2023). In programs that taught kids about a parent's illness, kids were about a third as likely to develop depression or anxiety over the next year or so (Havinga and colleagues, 2021). Those programs were for parents with depression or anxiety, and research on BPD families is newer. Still, understanding is the best place to start.



Here's what changes once you understand it.

- You stop taking the blame. A blowup becomes a symptom you can name.
- Your parent becomes more predictable. You learn the triggers and roughly how long a bad stretch lasts.
- You have words for it. “My parent has an illness called BPD” is a sentence you can say to a counselor or a friend.
- You can see the person underneath. Your parent is more than their worst days.

What tends to set things off?

The biggest trigger is fear of being left. People with BPD watch closely for signs that someone is pulling away, and they react hard when they think they see one.

That puts teenagers in a tough spot, because growing up means pulling away a little. You close your door, you want time with friends, you keep some things private. All of that is normal. To a parent with BPD, each one can feel like the first step toward being abandoned. No study has tested this exact point, but it follows from how the illness works, and it explains a lot of fights that seem to come out of nowhere.

Sometimes the trigger is tiny. A forgotten chore or the wrong tone of voice can hang over the house for days. Knowing the pattern won't stop the reaction. It does mean you can see it coming and choose how you respond. These example conversations aren't from a study, so put them in your own words.

You're heading out with friends and your parent is upset

Instead of

“Why do you always do this? I'm allowed to have a life.”

Try

“I'm going to Maya's until nine. I'll text you from there, and I'll be home at nine.”

A set time and a promise to check in speak to the fear underneath. An argument about your rights skips right past it.

Your parent says you don't love them

Instead of

"That's ridiculous. You're being crazy."

Try

"I do love you. I can tell you're really scared right now."

While the feeling is this strong, arguing the facts goes nowhere. Naming the feeling usually lowers the temperature.

Your parent goes silent after an argument

Instead of

Following them from room to room until they talk.

Try

"I'm going to do my homework. I'm here when you want to talk."

You can't pull someone out of a shutdown. Telling them where you are, and that you're staying, is enough.

What can I actually do?

More than you might think. Research on kids whose parent has a mental illness keeps finding the same few things that protect them, and you can start most of them this week.

Pick one steady adult

Your steady adult could be your other parent, a grandparent, an aunt or uncle, a coach, a teacher or your school counselor. Who it is matters less than how often you see them, because support that shows up regularly makes the biggest difference (Van Schoors and colleagues, 2023). The same review found that being close with a brother or sister protects kids too, so if you have one, look out for each other.

Who is in your corner?



● People I see every week

● People I could call

● Professionals

School counselor, a doctor, 988

Fill this in with a pencil. One name in the inner ring is a strong start.

Keep your own life going



When researchers asked kids in your position what helped, they named time with friends and ordinary activities (Bee and colleagues, 2014). Kids who coped by accepting what they couldn't change, looking for the good in things and taking their mind off it had less anxiety and depression (Van Schoors and colleagues, 2023). The ordinary stuff counts: practice, a sleepover, an afternoon doing absolutely nothing with your friends. You're allowed to have a good time while things at home are hard.

Tell one safe person

Kids with a parent who has a mental illness often keep it a secret, because they're afraid of being laughed at or teased (Dobener and colleagues, 2022). Carrying that alone wears you down. You don't need to tell everyone. One safe person is enough: a friend you trust, a relative, a counselor. In one review, kids said talking to someone helped even when the conversation wasn't about their parent at all, and one girl said talking to her pet made her feel better (Sawitzki and colleagues, 2025).



A school counselor is a good first choice. Talking with students about hard things at home is part of the job.

Have I become the parent?

Maybe you're the one who makes sure dinner happens. Maybe you're the one who calms everybody down, or the one your parent vents to about the other adults in their life. At the time, it just feels like being responsible.

Researchers have a name for it: role reversal. In a review of 14 studies, young people with a parent who had a mental illness described taking over their parent's job so often that the researchers had to add a new category to the standard model of how kids cope (Sawitzki and colleagues, 2025). Kids who do this are often praised for being mature. Of course, it's still too much weight for someone your age.

Whose job is it?

An adult's job	Your job
Calming your parent down every night	School and homework
Keeping the peace between your parents	Friends, practice, the things you love
Running the house	Sleep
Being the one your parent tells everything	Telling an adult when things are bad
Deciding whether your parent needs treatment	Asking for help for yourself

If the left column sounds like your week, tell your steady adult. Handing one of those jobs back to a grown-up is a real change.

Should I try to talk my parent into therapy?

You can, and you can also leave it to an adult. Your parent's treatment is their responsibility and their doctor's.

If you do bring it up, research on adults gives a few clues. People who were listened to without judgment and gently pointed toward help were much more likely to see a doctor or therapist afterward (Morgan and colleagues, 2025). Almost half of people who skip treatment don't think they need it, and most of the rest want to handle it on their own (Mojtabai and colleagues, 2011), so one conversation rarely settles it. In one study, parents with BPD said they wanted help being better parents (Zalewski and colleagues, 2015). That's usually a better way in than the word “disorder.”

Bringing it up for the first time

Instead of

“You need help. I looked it up, and I think you have BPD.”

Try

“I love you, and I can see how hard things have been. Would you talk to someone? I'd feel better knowing you had support.”

A diagnosis from your own kid lands as an accusation. Worry from your own kid is much harder to argue with.

In the middle of a fight

Instead of

"If you don't go to therapy, you're going to lose us."

Try

Saying nothing about therapy until you're both calm.

About one in five parents in one study of public mental health care feared losing custody of their kids over treatment (Busch and Redlich, 2007). A threat feeds that fear and makes treatment less likely.

I'll be honest: some people never go, no matter how the subject comes up. A trusted adult can carry this conversation better than you can. In research trials, a short family session where a counselor explains the illness to everyone helped kids feel less anxious (Solantaus and colleagues, 2010). Ask your steady adult whether your parent's therapist, or a counselor, could set one up.

When home doesn't feel safe

Understanding the illness helps you make sense of your parent's behavior. Being hurt is still never okay. If a parent hits you, threatens you, or leaves you without food or a safe place to sleep, tell an adult you trust or call one of these numbers. What happens next, including where you stay, is something to work out with that adult.

Free, confidential, and open all day and night

- 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline: call or text 988. You can call about your parent or about yourself.
- Childhelp National Child Abuse Hotline: call or text 1-800-422-4453.
- Crisis Text Line: text HOME to 741741.
- If anyone is in immediate danger, call 911.

Where to start this week

Five small steps. None of them depend on your parent changing.

- ☐ Write one name in the inner ring of your corner.
- ☐ Tell that person one true thing about what happens at home.
- ☐ Make one plan with friends, and keep it.
- ☐ Pick one job from the adult column and hand it back to a grown-up.
- ☐ Save 988 and 1-800-422-4453 in your phone.

Will my parent ever recover?



There's real reason for hope.

A review of 19 long-term studies found that remission from BPD, meaning a person no longer meets the criteria, is common. Once people reach remission, few slip back (Ng and colleagues, 2016). Treatments like dialectical behavior therapy, or DBT, were built specifically for BPD.

Recovery in everyday life, like steady relationships and work, can take longer than the symptoms do. Not everyone with BPD looks for help. If your parent never does, you can still love them and still look after yourself. Plenty of parents do recover, though, and families change with them.

Your own future belongs to you, too. Understanding the illness, a steady adult, friends, and your own ways of coping are the same things researchers link to kids doing well when a parent is unwell (Van Schoors and colleagues, 2023). In one study, several adults who grew up with a parent's mental illness went on to helping careers like counseling and social work (Patrick and colleagues, 2019). I don't think that's a coincidence. Growing up like this teaches you a lot about people, and what you do with that is up to you.





Hi, I'm Marley

I made these guides because my family needed them and nobody had written them yet.

I grew up in a family where emotions ran high and nobody had a word for why. Once I finally had one, I spent a summer digging through clinical research on borderline personality disorder to understand what I had been living with. These guides are what came out of it.

I'm a high school senior in Arkansas, and I want to become a psychiatrist. Every research claim in here is cited at the back, and the guides are free. Please share them with anyone who needs them.

“Nobody in my family had the language for what was happening. These guides are the thing I wish someone had handed us.”

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Most of the research on programs for children studied parents with depression or anxiety; studies of children of parents with BPD are fewer and more recent. The example conversations and the three diagrams were written for this guide. They follow the research above, and they were not themselves tested in a study. Crisis numbers were checked as current at the time of writing.